HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

Humility: What It Really Means

Given Monday 20 April 2026 · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem, Chapter 7

Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Kifayat al-Abidin) — Rabbi Avraham ben HaRambam **Chapter:** Perek 7 (ענוה — Humility) — Part 1 **Edition:** Feldheim

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Recap: Chapters 1–6

- **Chapter 1:** Two paths — the Tzaddik (basics) and the Chasid (beyond)
- **Chapter 2:** All middot are interrelated
- **Chapter 3:** Purity of motive — four levels
- **Chapter 4:** Compassion — first of the 13 Attributes. When in doubt → mercy
- **Chapter 5:** Generosity — four kinds: money, influence, intellect, faith
- **Chapter 6:** Calmness — intellect over emotion. Anger + arrogance linked; patience + humility linked. Sometimes anger is appropriate for spiritual matters.

Key connection: Rabbi Avraham taught in Chapter 6 that calmness and humility are interrelated, anger and arrogance are interrelated. This is why Chapter 7 (humility) follows Chapter 6 (calmness) — the less prone to anger, the more humble you are.

Note on structure: The chapters get longer as the book progresses — Rabbi Avraham seems to move from easier middot to harder ones. Chapter 7 is the longest chapter so far (expected 3–4 classes).

Part 1: How Bad Arrogance Is / How Beautiful Humility Is

Arrogance — Despised by God

הגאוה מאוסה לפניו יתעלה

- Arrogance is despicable before Hashem
- Shlomo HaMelech: תועבת ה' כל גבה לב — it's an abomination to God
- Mishlei lists **seven kinds of people Hashem hates** — the very FIRST is arrogant people (רום עינים)
- Then: murderers, liars, plotters, those who rush to evil, false witnesses, those who cause fights
- **Arrogance leads to denying God:**
- Parashat Ekev: ורם לבבך ושכחת את ה' אלהיך — when everything goes well (nice houses, good food), you become haughty → you forget Hashem

Humility — One of the Most Beautiful Traits

ענוה היא מן המעולות שבמדות הטרומיות

- Humility = the prerequisite for completeness as a human being
- Shlomo: ולפני כבוד ענוה — before honour comes humility

- **"Kavod" here doesn't mean honour/aggrandizement** — that would be the opposite of humility
- Kavod = **completion, wholeness** of a human being (as in: וכבוד והדר תעטרהו — Tehillim about God crowning humanity with grandeur)
- The Zohar also calls the neshamah "kavod"
- Meaning: **before you can be completed as a human → you need humility**
- Humility brings the fear of God: עקב ענוה יראת ה' — on the heel of humility comes yir'at Hashem

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Part 2: The Definition of Humility

Four Kinds of Humility

מתחלקת לכמה וכמה סוגים

Dimension	Two Sides
Inner vs. Outer	Inner humility (in your heart) vs. outer humility (behaviour, dress, conduct)
Vis-à-vis God vs. Humans	Humble before Hashem vs. humble before other people

Inner and Outer Must Be Symmetrical

- Some people act humble externally but aren't humble internally
- It's not enough to feel humble inside — your external actions must reflect it too
- **David HaMelech's testimony (Tehillim):**

לא גבה לבי — "My heart wasn't arrogant" = **inner humility**
ולא רמו עיני — "My eyes didn't act haughty" = **outer humility**
אם לא שויתי ודוממתי נפשי — "I kept silent" = **outer humility**
ולבי חלל בקרבי — "My heart is hollow within me" = **inner humility**

- **The Rambam in Hilchot Melachim:** Just as the Torah tells us to honour the king, so too the king is commanded to be humble: ולבי חלל בקרבי — same verse Rabbi Avraham quotes (he gets this from his father)

The Rabbi Yisrael Salanter Story

- Saw someone praying the Amidah with great kavvanah
- In Elokai Netzor: ונפשי כעפר לכל תהיה — "let my soul be like dust to everyone"
- Thought: this must be a very humble person
- A few moments later → saw the same person arguing arrogantly with someone
- Asked him about it → the man said: "Vis-à-vis Hashem I'm humble, but vis-à-vis other people I'm greater"
- **The lesson:** It's not enough to be humble before Hashem if you're arrogant before people

Vis-à-vis God AND Humans

Before God:

- Avraham: ואנכי עפר ואפר — "I am but dust and ash"
- David: ונקלותי עוד מזאת — when dancing with the Torah, Michal criticized him → he said "I'll be even more degraded than this"

Before other humans:

- David after killing Goliath → Shaul wants to marry him to Michal → David says: הנקלה בעיניכם התחתן במלך? ואנכי איש רש ונקלה — "Who am I? I'm a simple person"
- David to Shaul (who's chasing him): אחרי מי אתה רודף? אחרי כלב מת, אחרי פרעוש אחד — "Why chase me? I'm just a flea"

Part 3: What Humility Actually Means — The Surprising Definition

Arrogance Defined

שהכח השכלי באדם רואה עצמו נעלה מכפי שהוא

- Arrogance = **a person thinking about themselves more than they really are**
- You think you deserve more than you deserve
- You think you're cleverer, more beautiful, calmer than you really are
- Rabbi Avraham equates arrogance with **self-love** (loving yourself excessively)

Humility Defined — The Corollary

ומכאן מובנת הגדרת הענוה... היא הפוכה של גאוה

- First statement: Humility = seeing yourself as **less** than you are (the opposite extreme of arrogance)
- **But then he clarifies:**

אם יראה אדם עצמו פחות ממצבו בעולם **או כפי שהוא באמת בלא הוסף ובלי טעות**

- If a person sees himself as less than he really is, **OR as he really is without exaggeration**

The True Definition

- **Seeing yourself less than you are** = a temporary measure to counterbalance arrogance (like the Rambam's method: bend to the opposite extreme for a period)
- **The real, stable definition of humility:** See yourself **exactly as you are** — without adding, without exaggerating
- Recognize your talents — don't downplay them
- Recognize your deficiencies — don't hide them
- Don't think more of yourself than you are
- Don't think less of yourself than you are
- Later in the chapter, Rabbi Avraham writes explicitly: a person shouldn't think badly of himself

What Humility Is NOT

אך נאירה צימת לבך על ההבדל בין מי שמזגו מחייב הענוה הגבולה או ההתנברות והשפלות

- **Humility ≠ cowardice** (מורך)
- **Humility ≠ feeling low about yourself** (נברות ושפלות)
- **Humility ≠ debasing/embarrassing yourself** (ביזיון)

אדרבה ענוה פירושה שלא תינתן לגאוה ועם זאת לא תהיה שפל

- Humility means: **don't become arrogant, but also don't become lowly**

The Gemara in Sotah — Can a Humble Person Say "I'm Humble"?

- End of Masechet Sotah: when someone died, the Mishnah says "humility ceased"
- One of the rabbis said: "That's not true — I'm still around"
- This shows: asserting that you're humble doesn't mean you're not humble
- If you've worked on yourself and genuinely recognize it → that's fine
- **But:** Going around telling everyone "I'm a tzaddik" = obviously not humility (what's the purpose?)
- The key: it's about internal honesty, not external proclamation

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Part 4: Nature vs. Training

Born With a Tendency

- Like all middot: some people are born with a propensity toward humility, others toward arrogance
- The Rambam (Eight Chapters + Hilchot De'ot): every person has free will, but humans are born with different tendencies
- **This doesn't excuse anyone** — if you're born with more arrogance, you have a harder job, but you still must work on it

The Two Extremes

Reaching the highest humility:

- Born with propensity toward humility
- PLUS chinuch musari (ethical training)
- PLUS hitkashrut datit (spiritual/Torah training)
- PLUS histaklut mada'it (intellectual meditation)
- → Can reach the highest level of humility

Reaching the worst arrogance:

- Born with propensity toward arrogance
- PLUS habits of this world (competition, bossing people around)
- PLUS lack of spiritual training
- PLUS ignorance (never studying, never reflecting)
- → Can reach the worst level of arrogance

Most people: Somewhere in between — contradictions, sometimes working on it, sometimes not

The Foolish Person vs. David HaMelech

- Am ha'aretz shoteh: buys fancy clothes, walks with shtolz (arrogant bearing) → Shlomo says: גם בדרך כשסכל הולך לבו חסר — "When a fool walks, you can tell he's a fool"
- Yeshayahu: בנות ציון הלכו נטויות גרון — daughters of Zion walked with necks stretched high, eyes raised
- **Contrast with David:** מי אנכי ומי חיי משפחת אבי — "Who am I?"

Part 5: Training for Humility — Method 1: Working on Oneself

External Actions That Build Inner Humility

Stay away from:

שררה והתנשאות — domineering, asserting authority over others

קנאה ומדון — jealousy and competition

התהדרות במלבושים ובמרכבה — showing off with clothes and vehicles (horses then, cars now)

ישיבה בארמונות — living in the most extravagant accommodation

חברים בעלי גאוה — **associating with arrogant people** (company is crucial)

Actively pursue:

הכנעה לחכמים ולשמשם — act with humility before those greater than you, serve the wise

- Example: Elisha poured water on Eliyahu's hands — willing to serve his master
- The Mishnah: הוי מתאבק בעפר רגליהם — "Bask in the dust of the Chachamim"

סלוח למי שהרע לו — try to forgive those who wrong you

סבול שמיעת החרפה — learn to bear hearing insults without reacting

הצטמצם במלבושיו — dress simply, as needed — no more

- Example: Eliyahu wore only a hairy cloak and a belt

דירה פשוטה — live simply

- Example: Elisha was given a small attic room
- The Nevi'im were content with simplicity: "Let's take a beam and make a little place to sit"

התחבר עם ענוים — **associate with humble people**

- Example: When Shaul was with Doeg (bad company) → killed the Kohanim of Nov in anger
- When Shaul was with Shmuel (good company) → he was able to humble himself, threw off his royal garments, and prophesied

The Principle

ואלו דברים משותפים לפרישות ולענווה ולשאר סגולות המידות הטובות

- Working on humility also brings you to other good traits — especially abstinence
- Ultimately brings you toward encountering Hashem

Part 6: Training Method 2 — Stories from Torah

Positive Examples — Humble People

Person	What They Said/Did	Source
Avraham	ואנכי עפר ואפר — "I am dust and ash"	Bereishit 18
Yaakov	קטנתי מכל החסדים — "I don't deserve all the kindness"	Bereishit 32
Moshe	מי אנכי כי אלך אל פרעה — "Who am I to go to Pharaoh?" (while speaking to Hashem!)	Shemot 3
Moshe	ונחנו מה — "Who are we?"	Shemot 16
Moshe	המקנא אתה לי — "Don't be zealous for me" (re: Eldad & Medad)	Bamidbar 11
Moshe	The Torah testifies: עניו מאד מכל האדם — the most humble of ALL humans	Bamidbar 12:3
Shaul	הלא בן ימיני אנכי מקטני שבטי ישראל — "I'm from the smallest tribe"	Shmuel I 9
David	ואנכי איש רש ונקלה — "I'm a simple person"	Shmuel I 18
David	אחרי כלב מת, אחרי פרעוש אחד — "I'm just a flea"	Shmuel I 24
David	צעיר אנכי ונבזה — "I'm young and embarrassed"	Tehillim 119
Elisha	Went with his students to cut wood — willing to do manual labour alongside them	Melachim II 6
Hashem	מרום וקדוש אשכון ואת דכא ושפל רוח — "I dwell with the holy AND the humble"	Yeshayahu 57:15

Negative Example — Nadav and Avihu

The problem with the Midrash:

- Chazal say one reason Nadav and Avihu died was because of their **arrogance**
- Also: הורו הלכה בפני רבם — "they gave a halachic ruling in front of their teacher"
- Rabbi Avraham says: **DON'T take this at face value**
- Nadav and Avihu were prophets and anointed with the shemen hamishchah
- David said: אל תגעו במשיחי ובנביאי אל תרעו — don't criticize prophets
- It would be a great sin to call them genuinely arrogant people

Rabbi Avraham's interpretation:

- They weren't arrogant in any normal sense
- Their sin: they acted with courage and initiative WITHOUT consulting Moshe first
- They offered an unauthorized fire → without asking Moshe

  courage without taking counsel — אומץ לב ללא נטילת רשות
- For people on THEIR level → that tiny lack of humility = a serious deficiency
- **"They ruled halacha before their teacher"** doesn't mean an actual question was asked
- It means: they decided the answer themselves without bothering to consult

- They were so confident → they didn't think to ask
- **Even the shocking Midrash** — "when will Moshe and Aharon die so we can lead?" — same idea
- Not literally wishing them dead
- Acting as if they could make decisions independently → behaving like leaders before their time
- Not humble enough to recognize: there is a Moshe here — go ask him

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Key Takeaways

1. **Arrogance = thinking more of yourself than you are.** Humility = seeing yourself as you truly are.
2. **Humility ≠ self-debasement.** Don't confuse humility with cowardice, depression, or thinking badly of yourself.
3. **If you're good at something → acknowledge it.** Downplaying genuine strengths is NOT humility.
4. **Humility must be both inner AND outer, vis-à-vis God AND humans.**
5. **Company matters enormously.** Associate with humble people; distance from arrogant ones.
6. **Work on the external** (dress, behaviour, speech) → it will eventually affect the internal.
7. **Everyone is born with tendencies** — some toward humility, some toward arrogance. Either way, you must work on it.
8. **Nadav and Avihu** — their "arrogance" was not consulting Moshe. On their level, that was a fatal deficiency. Lesson: always take counsel, even when you're confident.

Preview: Next Class

- More stories of arrogant people (Korach, Datan)
- Mitzvot in the Torah designed to develop humility (many surprising ones)
- Intellectual meditation on humility

B'Ezrat Hashem

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